QUICK GUIDE

PHRASE COUNTING

What it is, how to spot it and what to do with it.

WHAT IT IS

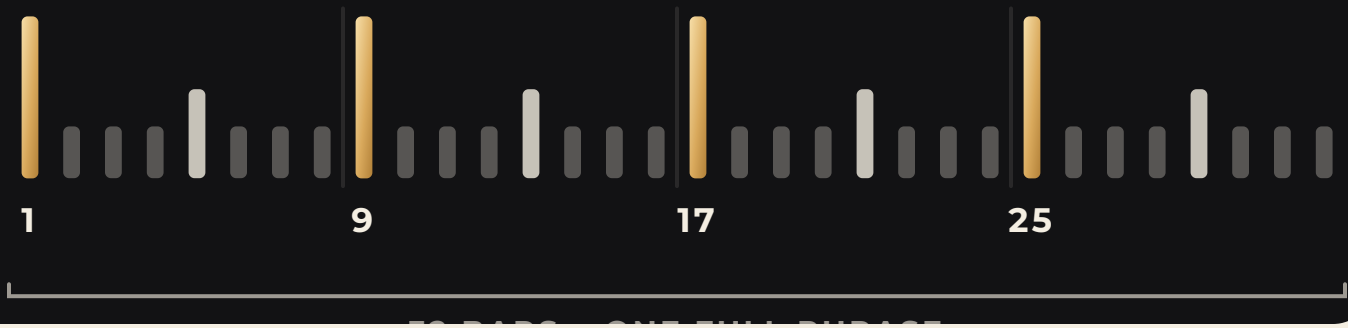
A phrase is a block of bars that makes one musical idea, most often 8, 16 or 32 bars long. Mixing on the phrase means two tracks change together instead of fighting each other.

WHAT YOU'LL NOTICE

Natural and intentional. The two tracks seem to belong together.

A 32-BAR PHRASE

BAR 1: START HERE



01

COUNTED IN BARS

Dance music is built in blocks of 4, 8, 16 and 32 bars.

02

CHANGES LAND ON THE BLOCK

Drops, breakdowns and new sounds usually arrive at the start of a block.

03

START ON BAR ONE

Bring the new track in on the first beat of a block, not in the middle.

DO THIS TONIGHT

Count one track out loud for 32 bars and note what changes.

- [ ] Count 1 to 8 out loud, over and over, with the track.
- [ ] Mark what changes at bars 9, 17 and 25.
- [ ] Start your next track on bar one of a new block.



PRACTICE & CHECK

PHRASE COUNTING: YOUR TURN

WHERE YOU'LL MEET IT AS A DJ

- Starting an intro as the outgoing track enters its last phrase.
- Lining up a drop with the end of the other track's outro.
- Knowing when you have time to loop, add an effect or swap bass.

QUICK CHECK

1. What can a perfect beatmatch still get wrong?

2. Where should the new track start?

3. How long is a typical full phrase?

Answer key: 1) Where the music changes. 2) On bar one of a new phrase. 3) 16 or 32 bars, built from blocks of 8.

REMEMBER

Match the beat. Then match the phrase.

YOUR NOTES

UP NEXT Hot Cue Map

